

CASE STUDY

The Fork in the Road: How LibreOffice Was Born from a Crisis of Trust

Name – Bipanchi Kalita

Registration no. – 24BOE10046

Section A: Understanding the Background and Root Cause of the Conflict

The background of LibreOffice is more complex than mere programming. It is a story of power, trust, and control within the world of open-source software. To understand the real reason for the creation of LibreOffice, you must look past the bright, flashing news and into the underlying structural conflicts that have been building for some time.

In the late 1990s and early 2000s, the software world was largely proprietary, and the applications for personal productivity were at the center of the conflict. Microsoft Office was the standard, and its hold on the world was broad, from the individual user to the school system and even the government. The problem, of course, was not merely the price of the software, but control. Microsoft's proprietary file formats meant that users were locked into its world, unable to escape even when other solutions were available.

But when Sun Microsystems acquired Star Division and then launched OpenOffice.org as an open-source project, it seemed like the breakthrough had finally arrived. For the first time, there was a viable and free alternative that could be used on different platforms for day-to-day office work. OpenOffice.org was able to gain popularity, and the project began to attract different developers and users from all over the world.

However, despite the open-source code, the project did not perfectly align with the principles of open-source software development. The major problem with OpenOffice.org was the centralized control. Sun Microsystems had complete control over the project and decided what to include and what not to include in the project.

One of the important structural features was the copyright assignment policy. The contributors were required to sign a contract that allowed Sun to share ownership of

what they created. While this may appear to be a trivial matter, it is important to note that this decision had more profound implications. What this essentially meant was that even though these individuals were contributing to the project for free, they did not have complete ownership of what they created. Essentially, this meant that a corporation now had a stake in what the community created.

In those days, this decision was not questioned too much, especially since Sun was generally considered to be supportive of open-source development. The corporation had a reputation for being supportive and having a relatively liberal attitude towards the development community.

The tolerance level had all along been based on trust, as opposed to a strong foundation. The system itself was neither fair nor balanced; it was only made to look that way by the actions of the management company. This is a crucial point, as it points to the fundamental flaw in the system: its viability depended on who was at the helm, as opposed to a set of clear principles that were being followed.

And then 2010 happened, and Oracle bought Sun Microsystems. This was more than a simple change of ownership; it was also a change in the management of projects like OpenOffice.org. Oracle had a very different reputation from the original management team, a reputation that focused on the bottom line and IP protection.

The change in management made all the concerns that had been floating around very real. The contributors to the project started to think about whether the work they were doing could be used for something entirely different from what they wanted to achieve. The copyright assignment, which had always looked like a reasonable request, suddenly looked very ominous.

The other important factor in this case is the silence of Oracle. Open-source communities are all about openness and collaboration. If there is little or no communication, and the communication is skewed in favor of one party, then there is little trust left.

It should also be noted that there is a difference between legal openness and practical openness. OpenOffice.org is legally open-source software because anyone is allowed to access the code, modify it, and share it. However, the software is not practically open-source software because the community did not have control over the way the software was being managed.

It should also be noted that there is a common misconception about open-source software. Many people believe that if software is open-source, then it must also be democratic. This is not necessarily the case.

The Oracle deal was a wake-up call that exposed the fundamental flaw in the system. The code was open to tweaking and re-use by contributors. However, they had no real say in the overall direction of the code. This was the final straw that swung the argument and shifted the mood.

The idea of forking was no longer seen as a threat but as a viable option. It has been argued that forking is a basic right for open-source code. This means that you can take the code and go your separate way. However, forking is not as easy as it sounds. It has real risks associated with it. It can result in loss of users and the need to build new infrastructure.

The internal problems facing OpenOffice.org made forking more and more difficult to ignore.

The bottom line is that LibreOffice was not born out of a single turning point but out of a complex array of factors. The OpenOffice.org model, which concentrated power in a single corporation, was a precarious model based on trust. The Oracle takeover of OpenOffice.org destroyed the trust, and the weaknesses of the model were then laid bare.

The lesson to be learned from this whole experience is that open-source projects are not only about the license but also about the model of governance. Open-source projects are about more than the access to the source code; they are about the access to the power and the transparency of the source code as well. Without the above, the open-source project risks becoming a kind of proprietary project.

SECTION B: Ethical Dimensions of Corporate Control in Open Source Projects

At the heart of the LibreOffice experience is a deeper ethical issue that we must all consider as we go about our open-source projects in the 21st century: does the fact that a corporation is investing heavily in the open-source project confer upon it the right to control the project? The answer to the above is not a simple yes or no.

Firstly, it is important to realize that corporate control is justified. Companies such as Sun Microsystems, and eventually Oracle, did not stumble upon OpenOffice.org by accident. Rather, they committed to it and ensured that it was maintained and further developed, including funding the appropriate infrastructure and ensuring legal compliance and stability.

In this context, corporate control makes perfect sense as a form of recompense for investment. Indeed, without such organizations, many open-source projects may not have been possible at all, especially when one considers how complex software projects are and how not all individuals may have access to the appropriate resources to support them.

Ethics change once we bring open source contributions into the spotlight. For instance, unlike other companies that operate on paid employees, open source software works on volunteers who contribute to its development without any pay. The only thing that drives them is curiosity and interest.

So, once again, the relationship that exists between a company and its community is based on trust. The community contributes to its development with the expectation that its contributions are used for the betterment of all. When a company takes too much ownership of that contribution, its trust is broken.

A very interesting case is that of OpenOffice.org's copyright assignment. When OpenOffice.org asked its contributors to assign joint ownership of its contributions to Sun and later to Oracle, it essentially gained legal power over contributions that were mostly developed by its community.

Under Sun's management, people were willing to accept this state of affairs, as they knew the company was acting in good faith. Sun appeared to be a relatively gentle player in the open-source community. However, when Oracle took over, things suddenly turned around. The way Oracle fought for intellectual property rights made people uneasy about what might be done with their work.

This example illustrates an important fact: what is ethical is not always based on rules but also on trust. If trust is not the foundation but a set of rules, then the system will always be unstable. If trust fails, what was once acceptable may no longer be acceptable.

It's useful to distinguish between ownership and stewardship. Ownership involves control and self-interest.

The ideal in open source is that corporations should be more like stewards than masters. They should provide support and resources to the open source development process and assist in steering it in the right direction. However, they should not be in control. The role of a steward is to facilitate collaboration and not dominate it.

Sun Microsystems was somewhat successful in this. It had significant power but used it in a way that didn't alienate the open source community. However, in the case of Oracle, it seems to have gone beyond the line. Its actions appear to have been a

transition from being a steward to being a master. This means that business interests came before the values of the open source community.

Another ethical issue to note is that the work of open source can be seen as a form of shared ownership. It can be argued that, given the hundreds or thousands of people who have a hand in the project, the final product can be seen as a form of shared ownership. It can then be argued that it is unjust for a single entity to have a level of control over the work.

One can argue that the people involved in the open source project agreed to the terms of the copyright willingly. It can be argued from a legal standpoint that no coercion is involved, and people can choose to agree or disagree to the terms of the copyright. However, the problem is that the average person involved in the open source project may not understand the implications of the agreement, and the lack of alternative options can be seen as a form of coercion, especially in the case of a large project requiring the assigning of the copyright in order to be involved in the project.

This leads to a bigger question of ethics: is it fair if people only accept something because they are given few choices? With OpenOffice.org, the people accepted the way that the organization was being managed because it gave them the opportunity to contribute to something that many people used. However, just because people accepted it does not make it fair.

The actions of Oracle also contributed to the question of ethics and fairness. When they took over Sun Microsystems and began to make changes to OpenOffice.org, the fact that they created a commercial version and stepped back from the community was seen as a sign that the priority was not to make open-source software but to make business. This is not fair.

Ethically speaking, the question that should be asked is not if corporations should be involved in open-source programs—they should be—but how they should be involved. In open-source programs, there should be collaboration between individuals and organizations. However, this collaboration should be done in a way that respects each side.

In my opinion, it is not ethical for corporations to have total control over open-source projects, especially considering how much of a role the community plays in the project. The control should be more distributed, with a clear and transparent decision-making process, community representation within the project leadership, and a clear policy for protecting what the community brings to the table.

However, removing the corporations entirely from the equation is neither practical nor necessarily desirable, as corporations bring stability, funding, and expertise to the project, which are all essential for large projects like this to succeed. The goal should be to ensure that the corporations do not overshadow the community.

The example of LibreOffice demonstrates the importance of ethical practices within the world of open-source software, as a project can have all the right technical skills, community participation, and user base, but if the ethical practice of the project is deemed unbalanced, the community will turn against it.

The delicate balance between corporate control and community freedom is the fine art of project development. Get it right, and the project soars to great success and sustainability. Get it wrong, and the result is fragmentation, conflict, and broken trust—much like what has occurred with the evolution of OpenOffice.org into LibreOffice.

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SECTION C: Evaluating the Decision to Fork

The decision to fork OpenOffice.org and start LibreOffice was not just about code. It was also a strategic, moral, and emotional decision made by a huge and uncertain community. In order to understand if this was the right decision, you have to consider it from different points of view. You have to think practically, morally, and in terms of future possibilities.

If you think back to when the fork happened in 2010, you will understand that the OpenOffice.org community was in a very complicated relationship of trust. It was a time when Oracle took control of the project. From that moment onwards, it was clear that the well-being of the project was not a priority. In that case, the old system was becoming more and more uncomfortable for the members of the OpenOffice.org community.

Therefore, forking was the best decision for them. It was a way for them to regain control and to establish a system of governance that was in line with open-source values. In that sense, by establishing The Document Foundation and creating LibreOffice, the members of the OpenOffice.org community were not just creating a new piece of code.

The fork was accompanied by real risks: it created division within the community, stretched resources in different directions, and created confusion among those who were unsure of what to believe. Organizations that were using OpenOffice.org were

faced with an important decision: to stay with the original project or switch to LibreOffice.

Some people believe that perhaps the community could have attempted other alternatives before deciding to fork. Perhaps they could have negotiated with Oracle to improve how things are run—demands for greater transparency, fewer monopolistic tendencies in managing copyrights, and greater representation of the community in critical decision-making processes.

But all this is predicated on an important presumption: that Oracle is willing to compromise. However, all signs seem to indicate that Oracle is unwilling to do so.

From the Oracle perspective, not being part of The Document Foundation or not sharing control may have appeared to be the rational thing to do. OpenOffice.org was worth some commercial value, and giving up control may have zipped away some possible commercial income. Companies have to answer to shareholders, and much of what they do is based on making money. However, if we are to view the situation with an ethical perspective, Oracle's actions may not seem as rational. The idea of control over collaborating with the community pushed the community away, and it shows an interesting conflict between what is rational for the business and what is rational for the community. If we are to discuss the fork of the project, then we should also discuss some counterarguments. One such argument is that the community should have stuck with OpenOffice.org and continued to contribute. They should have remained united and continued with the project, thus not creating any duplication of work. They may have eventually changed Oracle's mind or adapted to the situation.

This perspective prioritizes pragmatism over sticking to one's ideals and suggests that keeping things smooth and connected might have paid off in the near future. After all, not all forks succeed, and starting something new from scratch means that there are many unknowns involved.

However, while this perspective has its points, it also has its drawbacks. For one thing, it presumes that people had control over the existing system, which might not have been the case. The way decisions were made in a centralized manner meant that the group was not in control of steering the system in the way that they wanted. If you were to be in the system, you might have to agree to decisions that went against what you believed in.

Moreover, going along in the way that Oracle was in control of the system might have drained the enthusiasm of the contributors in the long run. When trust and control are gone, so is the enthusiasm for the system.

The story of LibreOffice is a testament to a simple fact: the fork was well worth it. It quickly attracted the major Linux distros, garnered a bushel of contributors, and has become the leading open-source office software suite. OpenOffice.org, which evolved into Apache OpenOffice, has become a shadow of its former self in terms of activity and significance.

The outcome, therefore, seems to indicate that the community's gamble ultimately proved to be a success. It created a product that aligned with its ideals and had the promise of long-term growth.

Therefore, while the process of forking is messy and not necessarily the clean or simple solution, it was the right solution in the circumstances. It addressed the fundamental problem of governance and helped rebuild the trust within the community.

SECTION D: Broader Lessons and Real-World Implications

The LibreOffice case is not an isolated incident. In fact, it is the reflection of the broader relationship between large corporations and the open-source community. By looking at other similar cases and applying this lens to the current situation, we can glean some important lessons on the future of open-source software development.

One of the best examples of this phenomenon is the MariaDB fork of the MySQL database. Just like OpenOffice.org, MySQL started as an open-source project but is currently owned by Oracle due to the Oracle acquisition of Sun Microsystems.

The similarity between the two cases is quite striking: not one, but two major open-source projects, OpenOffice.org and MySQL, both had forks due to the same event. This is not coincidental; rather, it is the reflection of the underlying phenomenon.

This piece highlights how important trust is to the world of open source. People will contribute more to projects that they feel are respecting them and echoing their own ideas. However, if trust is lost, even a successful project will begin to die off.

In modern times, large organizations often run many open-source projects. Many popular programs and tools are either created or at least built from scratch by large organizations. However, this begs one important question: is corporate dominance bad?

The answer to this question depends on how this dominance is being executed. If a large corporation is contributing most of the code and yet allowing everyone to

contribute to and govern this project, it can continue to be run as an open-source project. However, if this same dominance is being used to ram decisions through, it is similar to the OpenOffice.org case.

In order to evaluate whether or not a corporate steward is trustworthy, you can look for a number of key indicators, including:

- Transparency in decision-making
- Ongoing dialogue with the community
- Absence of binding legal traps such as mandatory copyright transfer
- Inclusion of the community's voice within governance
- Clear demarcation between business interests and project direction

When all these conditions are met, corporate support is beneficial. However, when they are not met, the probability of conflict increases manifold.

One more lesson that may be drawn from this situation is that proper governance is essential right from the start. Open-source projects start off small and may be run by a tight-knit group of individuals. However, as they grow in popularity and importance, governance is often left to be addressed at a later date, which may not be a good idea.

Some key points that I would advise individuals to keep in mind if they are looking to start a new open-source project include:

Firstly, contributors retain ownership of the code. This means that no single entity can claim ownership of the entire code.

Secondly, there should be a form of shared decision-making. This can be done by having a governing body that consists of members from different backgrounds.

Thirdly, rules should be set and documented. This includes how decisions are made, how conflicts are resolved, and how leadership is determined.

Fourthly, corporate involvement should be encouraged but not dominant. This means that while corporations can be involved in the process, they should not dominate it.

Lastly, transparency should be key. This means that decisions, discussions, and plans should be openly accessible to the members.

This will ensure that the Libre Office fork is avoided.

The story of LibreOffice serves as a counterexample to the notion that “open source” automatically translates to “fairness” and “democracy.” In other words, the experience of LibreOffice serves as a reminder that the absence of proper governance in the development process can lead to the favoring of certain voices over others.

The experience of LibreOffice has important implications for developers and users of open-source software.

For developers, the experience of LibreOffice serves as a reminder of the need to examine the governance of the development process prior to participating in the process.

For users of the software, the experience of LibreOffice serves as a reminder that software development is not merely about the code used in the development process but also about the individuals involved in the process.

In other words, the experience of LibreOffice has important implications that extend beyond the development process of the software and have important implications for the broader world of open-source software.

SECTION E: Personal Reflection and Learning

Before going into this case study, I had a preconceived notion that open source was a very simple concept. Anyone can use, modify, and share the code. It was a very technical concept, and all it meant was accessibility.

However, this case study has completely turned my concept around. Open source is not just about the code; it’s about the people who own the code. This case study has taught me to distinguish between legal open source and actual open source.

The thing that surprised me the most about this case study was the time that the community took to recognize the governance issues under Sun Microsystems. The copyright assignment issue was always there, but the community did not have a problem with it. This has taught me the importance of trust in any community. If the people trusted Sun Microsystems, then these issues were not important. However, when Oracle took over, these issues became very important.

This has made me realize something important. A system based solely on trust, without good fairness built in, is not robust. It will work for a while, but it’s vulnerable to changes in the leadership or motivations. Again, this is not unique to open source, but it’s relevant to many real-world groups and systems.

Another concern I have is the concept of copyright assignment. While it may seem like an esoteric legal concept, it's an important one. People contribute to something they're willing to contribute to, but they're asked to give up some level of ownership to a corporation. While it may make legal or structural sense, it's not necessarily fair. As an individual, I think contributors should have more control over what they contribute, especially in an open source setting. If the very idea of open source is to encourage sharing and mutual benefit, then assigning ownership to an entity goes against the spirit of open source.

The decision to fork the project and create LibreOffice has made a lasting impression on me. It was a difficult decision, to say the least. The community had to sacrifice a successful project, risk alienating users, and start from scratch. It was practically the more convenient option to stay with the status quo.

However, the community chose to stand by what was right, even if it was more inconvenient for them. It shows a strong commitment to the core values of the open-source movement.

If I were to imagine myself in the shoes of the community, I think I would have made the same decision to fork the project, even though it was far from easy. The risks and threats were a lot to bear, but at the same time, the lack of trust and fairness within the system would have made it no less difficult.

This case study has made me think more about the tools and technologies that we use as well. While functionality is important, as in whether the tool works or not, it seems to me that the real question is who is behind the tool and how the inner workings of the tool are run.

This case has helped change my thinking about open source from a more technical construct to a broader, more social-technical construct that incorporates people, organizations, ethics, and power relationships. This will certainly impact how I use or, in the future, become involved with open source as a contributor.

CONCLUSION

The story of LibreOffice serves as a compelling example of the role of governance, trust, and ethics in the life of an open-source project. Even though OpenOffice.org is considered to be an open-source project, the centralized structure of the project led to tension.

The acquisition of Sun Microsystems by Oracle Corporation served as the catalyst that highlighted the issues facing the OpenOffice.org project. When trust is lost and the

balance of governance is skewed, the likelihood of forking increases. In the case of the OpenOffice.org project, the birth of LibreOffice represents not only the birth of a new project but also the birth of the values of openness.

From the above, it is evident that openness in software development goes beyond the code. Openness also entails the governance and the decision-making process of the project.

The success of LibreOffice also demonstrates that people are willing to make sacrifices in the name of their values. It also reinforces the point that one should not put their trust in others, but should instead put their trust in balanced structures. This case is more relevant now that open source is growing and becoming more important in the field of technology. One should realize that open source is not just based on its code, but also on the values that it was created to uphold.